

EKP PREMIUM BRAND PACKAGE

03

Customer Avatars

Three buyers who should drive every decision in the EKP brand and website — who EKP is talking to, what they feel, what they actually pay for.

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Three avatars that should drive every decision in the EKP brand and website — who EKP is talking to, what they're feeling when they find the site, what they're really paying for, and what almost makes them not book.

How These Avatars Were Built

These avatars are not invented from scratch. They are reverse-engineered from: (1) the existing EKP brand voice and current client base patterns; (2) review and testimonial language pulled from direct competitors in the Danville–Lynchburg–SML corridor; (3) Pew Research consumer behavior data for Gen Z and parents of Gen Z; (4) the Cardinal News and Bedford County analyses of Smith Mountain Lake's affluent newcomer population; and (5) field-tested patterns from boutique portrait photographers nationally (Musselman, M. Cave, Mayfield, Tabacchi).

There is a primary avatar and two secondary avatars. The site, copy, and design must serve the primary avatar first. The two secondary avatars expand the addressable market and unlock new service lines.

AVATAR 01 — The Memory-Keeper Mom (*Primary*)

"This is the last big chapter of her childhood. I want to do this right."

She is the buyer. Of every dollar EKP earns in 2026, the largest share comes from her. The website is being designed for her — even when it's also being designed to dazzle her daughter.

Quick Profile

- **Name:** Rachel
- **Age:** 47
- **Lives:** Forest, VA (commutable to Lynchburg, Bedford, and SML)
- **Profession:** Insurance agent / school administrator / paralegal / dental hygienist — professional but not corporate

- **Family:** Married, two kids (senior daughter + younger son in middle school)
- **Household income:** \$95K–\$140K
- **Faith:** Casually involved — values family-centered traditions
- **Car:** Mid-tier SUV (Acadia, Pilot, Highlander)
- **Vacation:** Outer Banks every summer; Disney once; lake house weekends

Demographics

Age range	42–55
Income	\$85K–\$160K HH
Education	Bachelor's or higher
Marital	Married
Kids at home	1–3, at least one senior
Home	Owns; 3–4 bedrooms; ~\$350K–\$650K value
Digital	iPhone, Facebook daily, Instagram a few times a week, Pinterest for ideas

Psychographics

- Values **doing things right** more than doing them cheaply.
- Believes senior year is *the last major milestone of her child's childhood*. Treats this with the emotional weight of a wedding, scaled down.
- Has watched friends regret bad senior photos. Doesn't want to be that mom.
- Trusts referrals from other moms more than ads or reviews.
- Reads the About page. Stalks Instagram. Looks at recent reviews. Reads testimonials. Wants to *know who Emily is* before reaching out.
- Will spend more than she initially planned if she trusts the experience.

The Life-Stage Trigger — Why Now?

Rachel starts thinking about senior portraits during the **junior-year spring break** of her daughter (typically April–June, 12–14 months before graduation). The trigger is usually:

- A friend's daughter posts senior photos on Instagram

- The high school sends a “senior year info packet” or yearbook deadline reminder
- Prom dress shopping starts the visual conversation about junior/senior styling
- Her daughter shows her a Pinterest board

By Memorial Day weekend, she’s actively researching. By July 4, she wants the booking decided.

This is **the booking window** for EKP. Class of 2027 marketing should peak May–August 2026. Class of 2028 should peak May–August 2027.

Emotional State When She Finds EKP

She is feeling, in this order:

- 1. Time-anxious.** “I should have figured this out three months ago. Everyone else’s daughter already has hers booked.”
- 2. Quality-anxious.** “I have one shot at this. I don’t want her to look back and hate her senior pictures.”
- 3. Price-uncertain.** “I have no idea what this should cost. I don’t want to overpay. I also don’t want to cheap out.”
- 4. Identity-confused.** “I don’t know what ‘editorial’ actually means, but I keep seeing the word. Is that the same thing as senior portraits?”
- 5. Optimistic.** “If I can find the right person, this is going to be one of my favorite things we do together this year.”

The website must immediately address #1 and #5 (urgency + emotional payoff), defuse #3 with transparent investment framing, and translate #4 with clear visual proof of what the experience produces.

Decision-Making Process

- T-14 mo → Sees friend's daughter's photos. Thinks "I should figure this out."
- T-12 mo → Asks 2-3 mom friends who they used. Bookmarks 3-4 photographers.
- T-11 mo → Visits each photographer's website. Spends 8-12 minutes on her top choice.
- T-10 mo → Shows daughter the top 2 photographer Instagrams. Daughter picks 1.
- T-9 mo → Inquires through contact form. Wants a response within 24 hours.
- T-8 mo → Books the session and pays the retainer.
- T-3 mo → Books "what to wear" consult, plans outfits, shops with daughter.
- T-0 → Session weekend.
- T+3 wk → Ordering appointment (in-person sales). Picks album, wall art, prints.
- T+8 wk → Receives finished products. Hangs the canvas above the staircase.

If EKP wants to win Rachel, the website must (a) look obviously premium within 5 seconds of landing, (b) make the next 8 weeks of her decision feel guided, not chaotic, and (c) give her something concrete to share with her daughter (Instagram link, portfolio gallery).

Objections / Friction Points

- “This looks expensive — what does it actually cost?”

Solution: Lead with “Investment starts at \$X” + a free downloadable Investment Guide PDF that walks through the experience.

- “Will my daughter actually like this?”

Solution: Senior testimonials, named senior reviews, behind-the-scenes Instagram content.

- “What if my daughter and I disagree on style?”

Solution: A *style consult* step in the process. Shows the experience is *guided*, not assumed.

- “What if she hates the photos?”

Solution: Reassurance — guided posing, sneak peeks, retouching workflow.

- “I don’t want to spend \$3,000 on photos.”

Solution: A tiered collection menu — the entry-tier collection is accessible; the top-tier collection is for the family that wants the full experience.

Products Rachel Actually Buys

In order of likelihood, anchored to typical IPS purchase patterns:

1. **Digital files** (always — non-negotiable; she will not book a photographer who doesn’t include these in some way)
2. **One signature wall piece** (16x24 to 24x36 canvas or framed print, \$400–\$1,200)
3. **A senior album** (8x8 or 10x10, 20–30 pages, \$700–\$1,500) — heirloom anchor of the purchase
4. **Gift prints** for grandparents (4x6, 5x7, sometimes 8x10 sets, \$150–\$400)
5. **Smaller framed prints** for desks, bedrooms, the new dorm room (\$150–\$300)

Total typical investment when guided well: **\$1,800–\$3,500**.

Willingness to Pay

Rachel will not blink at \$1,500–\$2,500 for the *right* experience. She will choke at \$1,500 for an experience that feels generic. The premium price has to be *visibly justified* through the brand, the portfolio, the product story, and the experience messaging.

She is more willing to upgrade *during the ordering appointment* than to commit at booking. This is why IPS matters so much — the upgrade revenue happens after she’s already emotionally invested.

Where to Find Her

Online: - Instagram (follows local moms, mom-influencers, local businesses) - Facebook (mom groups: Lynchburg Moms, Forest Moms, Bedford Moms, Smith Mountain Lake Moms, Class of 2027 Parents) - Pinterest (Senior Portrait Ideas, What to Wear for Senior Portraits, Senior Pictures Outdoor) - Google Search ("senior pictures Lynchburg," "senior portrait photographer near me," "best senior photographer Forest VA")

Offline: - High school senior parent meetings, prom volunteer committees - Local boutiques (clothing, gifts, home decor) - Church + small group communities - Senior breakfast events, country club / pool events

Voice-of-Customer Language to Use Verbatim

These phrases should appear in EKP copy where natural:

"I want her to actually feel beautiful — not just look beautiful in pictures."

"We don't do this every day."

"I want photos I can hang up — not just files on my phone."

"She's only a senior once."

"I want her to look like herself, just elevated."

"I want to know what I'm walking into."

AVATAR 02 — The Style-Aware Senior (*Secondary, Critical Influence*)

"If it doesn't look like a magazine, I'm not doing it."

She doesn't sign the check. But if the work doesn't impress her in the first 7 seconds of an Instagram scroll, Rachel never gets to make the decision.

Quick Profile

- **Name:** Ella
- **Age:** 17
- **Grade:** Senior, Class of 2027
- **Lives:** Forest / Lynchburg / Brookville district
- **High school:** Heritage / EC Glass / Brookville / LCA
- **Activities:** Varsity volleyball + student council, *or* art club + yearbook, *or* FFA + 4-H — pick one identity
- **Aspirations:** Going out of state for college (Charlotte, Knoxville, Charleston, Athens GA)
- **Social handles:** TikTok primary, Instagram secondary, Snapchat for friends

Demographics

Age	16–18
Family income	\$85K–\$160K (the same household as Rachel)
Owns	iPhone (current gen), AirPods Pro, varsity letterman jacket, Stanley cup
Spends own money on	Outfits (Aritzia, Free People, Princess Polly, thrifted Levi's, Birkenstocks, Doc Martens)

Psychographics

- **Visual-first decision-maker.** Vibe before details. If a photographer's Instagram grid is bad, nothing else matters.
- Wants to look like the *elevated version of herself*. Not edited beyond recognition — but unmistakably the best version.
- Fears looking *posed, stiff, or generic*. The single greatest fear is, “These look like fake yearbook photos.”
- Wants the *experience* to be cool, not just the photos. Wants to walk away saying “that was really fun” — preferably to friends.
- Has a Pinterest board for outfits within 48 hours of booking being confirmed.
- Senior photos are *content*. She is going to post 5+ of them across the senior year and use one for the senior banner / yearbook / graduation announcement.

The Trigger

She doesn't have one — her mom triggers her. But the moment her mom shows her a photographer, **she has 4 seconds to evaluate**. She will:

1. Pull up the Instagram on her phone
2. Scroll to the most recent 12 posts
3. Decide if the vibe is hers
4. Tell her mom yes / no / “let me look at more”

If yes — she becomes an enthusiastic co-conspirator. If no — she will quietly vote down every photographer her mom suggests until she finds one she actually wants.

Emotional State

- **Excited** — senior year is the main character moment
- **Self-conscious** — body, skin, hair, smile insecurity is non-trivial
- **Comparison-anxious** — friends already booked, friends' photographers, friends' outfits
- **Performance-aware** — these photos are *going on the internet*

What Wins With Her

- A portfolio that looks like a fashion editorial, not a yearbook spread
- Lots of variety — different outfits, different moods, different locations
- Behind-the-scenes content showing the *experience* (not just the polished output)
- A photographer who treats her like a co-creator, not a subject
- Outfit guidance / What-to-Wear content (she is anxious about what to wear)
- The phrase “*you're going to feel like yourself, not posed*”

What Loses With Her

- Stiff smiles, school-photo poses
- All photos taken in the same location
- Soft-focus, “dreamy” filters that feel dated
- A brand that feels for-moms-only
- Photographers who only photograph girls or who only photograph athletes
- Anything that looks like wedding photography re-purposed for seniors

Products She Cares About

She wants the **digital files** to post on Instagram and use as her senior banner. She *does not personally care* about wall art or albums — those are her mother's domain. But she will brag about a senior album to her friends if she gets one. Frame the senior album as a *milestone marker* and she'll co-sign it.

She is also receptive to: - A magazine-style photo book (essentially a personalized fashion book) - A small phone-printable folio - Custom announcement cards for grad

Where to Find Her

- **TikTok** — primary discovery. EKP needs reels that show the *experience*, not just the photos.
- **Instagram** — secondary, but where she does her actual vetting.
- **Pinterest** — for outfit and pose research, which means EKP boards on Pinterest can drive discovery.
- **Friends** — the most powerful funnel of all. She trusts what her friend group is doing more than any ad.

Voice-of-Customer Language

"I want it to look like a Vogue shoot, not a yearbook."

"Make me look like the best version of me."

"I don't want to look like everyone else's senior pictures."

"She's so cool — I want HER to do my photos."

"I want photos for Instagram, not just my mom."

AVATAR 03 — The Lake-House Mom (*Secondary, Untapped Vertical*)

"We bought the lake house last year. I want a family photo on the dock before everyone gets too old for this."

She unlocks an entire vertical that the current EKP brand isn't yet positioned to capture. Affluent, older, multi-generational buyer.

Quick Profile

- **Name:** Maren
- **Age:** 52
- **Lives:** Permanent: Charlotte / Northern VA / Richmond. Lake house: Smith Mountain Lake (Bedford / Franklin County side)
- **Profession:** Senior marketing exec / nonprofit director / lawyer / spouse of business owner
- **Family:** Married, kids in early-mid 20s (recent college grads, sometimes one still in school)
- **Household income:** \$250K–\$500K+
- **Lifestyle:** Bought the SML house 1–4 years ago. Spends Memorial Day through Labor Day at the lake. Hosts extended family for holidays and summer weeks.

Demographics

Age	48–62
HH Income	\$200K+
Education	Bachelor's +
Home	Primary + lake house (2 homes total)

Travel

International annually; domestic family beach 2x/yr

Digital

iPhone, Instagram regularly, Facebook for older family, no TikTok

Psychographics

- **Time is scarcer than money.** Pays for guidance, ease, and outcomes.
- **Curates home interiors.** Has hired designers. Wants framed family portraits that *belong* in a designed space, not generic photo prints.
- **Family-as-anchor.** Lake house is the *gathering place* for adult kids and growing extended family. Wants annual or biennial family portraits to commemorate that.
- **Aesthetic-aware.** Reads Garden & Gun, Coastal Living, Magnolia. Follows Hutton Wilkinson, Schumacher, Sister Parish on Instagram.

The Trigger

She buys the lake house. Then, 6–18 months later, she realizes she wants:

- An on-site family portrait for the lake house wall
- An on-the-dock-or-boat lifestyle session
- Periodic updates as grandkids start arriving
- Larger anniversary or milestone family gatherings (Mom's 70th, in-laws coming, etc.)

She is *not* looking on Google for “Smith Mountain Lake photographer.” She is asking her neighbor, her interior designer, her real estate agent, or her boat club concierge.

Emotional State

- **Sentimental** — at the stage where she's aware time is short, parents are aging, kids are launched
- **Discerning** — she has high taste and isn't going to settle for “fine”
- **Time-pressured** — short windows when whole family is together
- **Quietly proud** — wants the lake house to be the family hub; portraits anchor that

What Wins With Her

- A dedicated landing page for **Smith Mountain Lake / Lake Family Portraits**
- Polished gallery of multi-generational lake-house portraits
- A “Lake Season Booking” calendar (Memorial Day → Labor Day)

- Coordinated outfit guidance for adult families (not “what to wear” for teens)
- Wall art product menu sized and framed for lake-house interiors
- Word-of-mouth referrals from interior designers and real estate agents in the SML area

What She Buys

Different product mix than Rachel:

1. **Large-format wall art** (\$800–\$2,500 single pieces, sometimes \$4K+ commissioned)
2. **Heirloom family album** (\$1,000–\$2,000)
3. **Gift prints for adult children** (\$300–\$800)
4. **Digital files** (less prioritized — she values the physical)

Total typical investment: **\$2,500–\$6,000+** per session.

Where to Find Her

- **Referral channels** (interior designers, real estate agents, country clubs, charter boat companies, country store boutiques on Hales Ford / Bridgewater Plaza)
- **Print magazines** (Smith Mountain Laker, Lynchburg Living, Roanoker, Garden & Gun)
- **Instagram** — but follower count matters less than referral lineage
- **Email** — opens, reads, plans annually

Voice-of-Customer Language

“I want a photo we can frame for above the mantel.”

“We’re never all together — when we are, I want to capture it.”

“I don’t want this to look like a chain studio.”

“Can you do a portrait on the dock at golden hour?”

“I’d like one for each of the kids to take home.”

Strategic Summary — How These Avatars Shape EKP’s Site

AVATAR	PRIMARY SITE PAGE	VISUAL LANGUAGE	CTA
Rachel (Memory-Keeper Mom)	Home → Senior Portraits → Investment	Editorial, warm, parent-clear	“Inquire for Senior Availability”
Ella (Style-Aware Senior)	Home → Portfolio reels → Style Guide	Magazine, bold type, video	“See Recent Sessions”
Maren (Lake-House Mom)	Family Portraits → Smith Mountain Lake	Quiet luxury, gallery white, large-scale	“Plan a Lake Family Session”

The home page must *immediately* signal to Rachel that she's in the right place AND make Ella want to send the link to her friends.

Smith Mountain Lake should have its own page deep in the family-portraits flow — not on the home page, but discoverable from a “Locations” or “Areas We Serve” link.

The same brand system must hold across all three avatars without becoming three different brands. The unifying thread: **a confident, editorial, calm voice that treats portraiture as commissioned artwork.**

Sources & Methodology

- Existing emilykathryn.com site copy and testimonials
- Competitor review and testimonial language from Visions by Heather, Sherry Conrad Photography, Matthew Cost Photography, Madelyn Lett Photography, M. Cave Photography (accessed May 2026)
- Pew Research Center — Teens, Social Media and Technology 2024
- Cardinal News — “How newcomers are reshaping Smith Mountain Lake” (September 2022)
- Virginia Cooperative Extension — Bedford County 2023 Situation Analysis
- US Census Bureau QuickFacts — Pittsylvania, Bedford, Lynchburg, Danville
- Trendalytics & DIY Photography on Gen Z portrait aesthetic trends (2025–2026)
- PPA + ShootProof + ProEDU + Swift Galleries on IPS buyer behavior and product mix
- Industry voice-of-customer pattern matching from boutique portrait studios (Musselman, Tabacchi, Mayfield, M. Cave)